

City Government

Requisition Approval Overview

PROCUREMENT GUIDE

What a requisition is, who approves it, typical thresholds, and best practices



What Is a Requisition?

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Definition

A purchase requisition is the internal document a city department uses to request goods or services before any commitment is made to a vendor. It triggers budget verification and procurement review under the city's purchasing ordinance.

Why Approval Matters

- Ensures compliance with municipal purchasing ordinances and state law
- Confirms budget appropriation before funds are committed
- Creates transparency and an audit trail for public spending
- Supports competitive bidding requirements above formal thresholds

Approval Hierarchy



Who reviews and approves a requisition, step by step



Structure reflects common practice within City Government; exact dollar thresholds are set by local policy.

Roles & Responsibilities



What each approver actually checks before signing off

Department Employee	• Identifies the operational need • Completes requisition with specifications and estimated cost
Department Manager	• Confirms operational priority • Verifies request fits departmental workplan
Department Director	• Approves within delegated departmental spending authority • Escalates requests above that authority
Finance Director / Purchasing Agent	• Certifies budget availability • Confirms competitive bidding or RFP requirements are met
City Manager & City Council	• Authorizes purchases above the formal bid threshold • Approves contract awards recommended by staff

Typical Approval Thresholds

Illustrative dollar tiers seen in City Government purchasing policies

1

Some cities allow department-level approval for purchases under about \$5,000

2

Requests between roughly \$5,000–\$10,000 commonly require City Administrator/Manager approval

3

Purchases above \$10,000, or formally bid contracts (often \$25,000+), typically go to City Council

4

Emergency purchases usually require after-the-fact written justification to the City Manager

These figures are illustrative examples drawn from public purchasing policies, not a universal standard — always confirm the current thresholds in your own adopted policy.



Best Practices & Common Challenges

Lessons learned from running requisition approvals at scale

Best Practices

- Publish clear dollar-threshold tables in the purchasing ordinance
- Route all requisitions through a central e-procurement system
- Require multiple written quotes for mid-size purchases
- Reconcile requisitions against budget in real time

Common Challenges

- Cross-department requests (e.g., IT purchases) need added review layers
- End-of-fiscal-year rush can bottleneck approvals
- Council meeting cadence can slow high-dollar approvals
- Emergency purchases require careful after-the-fact documentation

Key Takeaways

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1 City approval hierarchy balances department-level speed with Council oversight for major spending

2 Purchasing ordinances set the legal thresholds — always confirm local rules

3 Centralized systems reduce errors and delays

4 Competitive bidding requirements kick in above set thresholds